claim the French throne; he would agitate for the next twenty years, doing an ill turn to the French throne whenever he could, but he would never again rule any country other than Navarre. In 1387, he would come to a particularly nasty end; accidentally set on fire while wrapped in a brandy-soaked sheet to treat a skin condition, he would linger for fifteen excruciatingly painful days before finally dying in agony.[17]

The Treaty of Bretigny, which had allowed John of France a last visit home, had guaranteed that neither Edward III of England nor the Black Prince would launch another challenge. England and France were, theoretically, at peace.* But the peace, fatally fragile, soon crumbled. The fighting restarted on the Spanish peninsula.

Pedro of Castile, inheriting the throne after his father's untimely death of plague, had spent the first fifteen years of his reign in a territorial war with Pedro of Aragon. He was, says Froissart, "a cruel man . . . of such a horrid disposition, that all persons feared and suspected him." He was, in fact, no worse than his brother kings in England and France; but fifteen years of war had not increased his popularity with his own people, any more than it had made John II more beloved by the French.[18]

Right after Charles V's coronation, Pedro of Castile's illegitimate half brother, Enrique of Trastámara, challenged his rule, and "the kings of France and Aragon undertook to place him on the throne." This was a reasonable enough decision on the part of Charles V of France; an alliance with Aragon, plus a Castilian king who owed his throne to France, would certainly provide a useful wall against further armies marching in from Navarre. A joint French-Aragonese army assembled and invaded Castile. Pedro summoned his barons and knights, but they too were war-weary and thinned by plague, and "scarcely any came."

Pedro was forced to flee from his country into Gascony, where he asked for an audience with Edward the Black Prince and (says the *Canterbury Chronicle*) "begged him most urgently to give him military assistance." As justification, he pointed out that he and the Black Prince were blood kin. The Black Prince's great-grandmother, wife of Edward I, was Eleanor of Castile, Pedro's great-great-great-aunt, which made the two men cousins, three times removed.[19]

Most European royal families were at least cousins three times removed, but the Black Prince immediately agreed. The alliance would, after all, bring him face-to-face with the French again, and without breaching the Treaty of Bretigny.

In 1367, Pedro the Cruel marched back into Castile, accompanied by the Black Prince and an English army. The English-Castilian army defeated the